

MC 7004: News Media & Governance

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Office Hours: Wed 3 pm - 5 pm Class Hours: Thu 3 pm - 5:50 pm
Office: Hodges 255 Classroom: Hodges 225

Overview

This course examines the changing relationships among news media, political institutions, political elites, and citizens. We will study how news organizations operate within political and economic systems, how governments and political actors shape news, and how media influence political attention, campaigns, public opinion, polarization, and democratic accountability. We will also examine how changes in the information environment, including social media, algorithmic recommendation, content moderation, and generative AI, are reshaping news production, news consumption, and governance.

Throughout the course, we will connect classic theories of political communication with recent research on digital media and artificial intelligence. Particular attention will be given to questions of democratic performance: who controls political information, which issues receive attention, how citizens encounter and respond to news, and how emerging communication technologies redistribute power among media organizations, technology platforms, governments, and the public. We will also critically evaluate the theories, research designs, and methods used to study these questions.

Readings

For each week's readings, you should be prepared to discuss the following questions in class:

1. What are some of the major *theoretical* perspectives that structure research in a given area, what are their major strengths and weaknesses, and how do they compare with other perspectives you're familiar with (encountered in the course or elsewhere)?
2. (If empirical research) What do you see as some of the major strengths and weaknesses of the *methods* used to investigate the subject? What methodologies, broadly conceived (e.g., basic issues of design, measurement, etc.) do you feel are most appropriate, given the subject of inquiry, and to what degree do you think the substantive conclusions drawn are dependent on the particular methods employed?

3. Do the authors engage with each other? Is this engagement fruitful for furthering the field? Would we learn more as scholars by more study in this area? What do we still not know?
4. What are the major *implications* of the findings for democratic theory and public policy? What relevance do the studies have for *your interests*? What does the study say about the way in which the American political system operates in practice – does the system live up to its billing as a democracy? According to what expectations and what definition of democracy?
5. What are the implications for practitioners in polling, campaigns, and media?
6. How can this research be *improved*, in your view? What theories, methods and substantive foci deserve more attention in future research?

Evaluation

Final grades in this course are based on your success in the 3 areas below.

1. **Participation (10%):** During classes, students may earn participation points by actively engaging in discussion. These points are not freebies for sitting in class. This participation should demonstrate that you have read and carefully thought about the readings prior to class. To merit credit, your participation should be intelligent, informed, and frequent. If it becomes apparent that many in class have not read, I will administer a pop quiz which will take the place of participation points. It is in everyone's best interest to be prepared and thus, avoid quizzes!
2. **Discussion prompt (40%):** To facilitate thoughtful discussion, you need to submit a written answer to one discussion question each week. For each class session, I will post one to three discussion questions for that day's readings. You will select one (and only one) to answer in written form. However, you will think about any other listed questions (as well as the six generic questions listed above and arrive at class with useful thoughts to share. For the written response, you will submit a 300- to 500-word response in the designated Moodle assignment. You can simply submit the text of your response (i.e., no need for headers, titles, names). You need not write the question; if I cannot identify the question to which you are responding, then that means there is something wrong with your response. Written responses are due by 1 pm on the Wednesday preceding class. We will build our classroom discussion primarily around your written responses, so you should be prepared to share and elaborate upon them. Your top 8 discussion prompt essays will be considered for grading. For instance, if you submit 10 essays, the highest-scoring 8 will be used. If only 8 essays are submitted, those 8 will be used for grading.
3. **Research paper (50%)**
 - **Research paper outline (5%):** Submit a detailed paper outline including the research question, tentative theory and hypotheses, a sketch of relevant literature, possible variables and methodological approach, a description of data, and at least 10 formatted citations. **Due Oct 8 before class**

- **Research paper midway report (5%):** A 1-page report summarizing what you have done and what else needs to be done. **Due Nov 5 before class**
- **Final research paper (30%):** A 10-page double-spaced research paper (not including figures, appendices, tables and references) examining a topic that reveals, in some way, the connections of media strategies and governing strategies. My preference is that the paper lay out a research design to test some proposition you develop and actually test hypotheses using data; this may be data you have gathered or existing data. In either case, this paper should explore the ideas and hypotheses of our readings and extend them to new situations and cases. Students should view this paper as a preliminary draft of a conference paper, thesis, or dissertation chapter. **Due Dec 11 at 11:59 pm**
- **Class Presentation (10%):** We will devote the last class to presentations on the research you have done for your research paper. This presentation should be styled after an academic conference paper presentation lasting no more than 15 minutes. See the rubric on Moodle for guidelines.

Grading Scale

University policy is to utilize a plus/minus grading scale. Below is the 10-point +/- grading scale I will use for this class. A's are reserved for excellent & exceptional work, B's suggest your work is very good, C's are for satisfactory work.

96.5 and above	A+
93.50 – 96.49	A
90.00–93.49	A-
86.50–89.99	B+
83.50–86.49	B
80.00–83.49	B-
76.50–79.99	C+
73.50–76.49	C
70.00–73.49	C-
69.99 and below*	F
*there are no D grades in grad. courses	

Course Outline

Week 01, 08/24 - 08/28: Course intro

Required Readings:

1. Syllabus
2. Sparrow, B. H. (2006). A Research Agenda for an Institutional Media. *Political Communication*, 23(2), 145–157.

Week 02, 08/31 - 09/04: No Class - Dr. Chen will be at APSA

Week 03, 09/07 - 09/11: Normative Roles of News Media in Democracy

Required Readings:

1. Gurevitch, M., & Blumler, J. G. (1990). Political communication systems and democratic values. In J. Lichtenberg (Ed.), *Democracy and the mass media* (pp. 269–287). Cambridge University Press.
2. Habermas, J. (2006). Political communication in media society: Does democracy still enjoy an epistemic dimension? The impact of normative theory on empirical research. *Communication Theory*, 16(4), 411-426.
3. Lorenz-Spreen, P., Oswald, L., Lewandowsky, S., & Hertwig, R. (2023). A systematic review of worldwide causal and correlational evidence on digital media and democracy. *Nature Human Behaviour*, 7(1), 74-101.
4. Lawrence, R. G. (2024). Media, Communication, and Democratic Decline: Thoughts on The Paradox of Democracy. *Political Science Quarterly*, qqae115.

Week 04, 09/14 - 09/18: Media as Commodity

Required Readings:

1. Hamilton, J. (2004). *All the News That's Fit to Sell: How the Market Transforms Information into News*. Princeton University Press. Chapter 1
2. Zuboff, S. (2023). The age of surveillance capitalism. In W. Longhofer & D. Winchester (Eds.), *Social theory re-wired: New connections to classical and contemporary perspectives* (3rd ed., pp. 203–213). Routledge
3. Munger, K. (2020). All the news that's fit to click: The economics of clickbait media. *Political Communication*, 37(3), 376-397.
4. Yun, J. R. (2024). The value and price of digital media commodities. *Media, Culture & Society*, 46(2), 219-234.

Week 05, 09/21 - 09/25: Political elites, government, and the news

Required Readings:

1. Bennett, W. L. (1990). Toward a theory of press-state relations in the United States. *Journal of Communication*, 40(2), 103-125.
2. Arnold, R. D. (2004). *Congress, the press, and political accountability*. Princeton University Press. Chapter 1.
3. Kingdon, J. W. (2014). *Agendas, Alternatives, and Public Policies*. Pearson. Chapters 2-4

Week 06, 09/28 - 10/02: News media agenda setting**Required Readings:**

1. McCombs, M. E., & Shaw, D. L. (1972). The agenda-setting function of mass media. *Public Opinion Quarterly*, 36(2), 176–187.
2. McCombs, M. E. (2005). A look at agenda-setting: Past, present and future. *Journalism Studies*, 6(4), 543-557.
3. Carpenter, D. (2023). Agenda democracy. *Annual Review of Political Science*, 26(1), 193-212.
4. Walgrave, S., & Van Aelst, P. (2006). The contingency of the mass media's political agenda setting power: Toward a preliminary theory. *Journal of Communication*, 56(1), 88-109.

Week 07, 10/05 - 10/09: No class - Fall break**Week 08, 10/12 - 10/16: Campaigns****Required Readings:**

1. Jacobson, G. C. (2015). How do campaigns matter? *Annual Review of Political Science*, 18(1), 31-47.
2. Lau, R. R., & Rovner, I. B. (2009). Negative campaigning. *Annual Review of Political Science*, 12(1), 285-306.
3. Ansolabehere, S., & Iyengar, S. (1994). Riding the wave and claiming ownership over issues: The joint effects of advertising and news coverage in campaigns. *Public Opinion Quarterly*, 58(3), 335-357.
4. Lenz, G. S. (2009). Learning and opinion change, not priming: Reconsidering the priming hypothesis. *American Journal of Political Science*, 53(4), 821-837.

Week 09, 10/19 - 10/23: Media and Polarization**Required Readings:**

1. Prior, M. (2013). Media and political polarization. *Annual Review of Political Science*, 16(1), 101-127.
2. Levendusky, M. S. (2013). Why do partisan media polarize viewers? *American Journal of Political Science*, 57(3), 611-623.
3. Kubin, E., & Von Sikorski, C. (2021). The role of (social) media in political polarization: a systematic review. *Annals of the International Communication Association*, 45(3), 188-206.
4. Esau, K., Choucair, T., Vilkins, S., Svegaard, S. F., Bruns, A., O'Connor-Farfan, K. S., & Lubicz-Zaorski, C. (2025). Destructive polarization in digital communication contexts: a critical review and conceptual framework. *Information, Communication & Society*, 28(8), 1499-1520.

Week 10, 10/26 - 10/30: News consumption and the changing information environment**Required Readings:**

1. Bennett, W. L. (2008). Changing citizenship in the digital age. In W. L. Bennett (Ed.), *Civic life online: Learning how digital media can engage youth*. The MIT Press.
2. Gil de Zuniga, H., Weeks, B., & Ardevol-Abreu, A. (2017). Effects of the news-finds-me perception in communication: Social media use implications for news seeking and learning about politics. *Journal of Computer-Mediated Communication*, 22(3), 105–123.
3. Boczkowski, P. J., Mitchelstein, E., & Matassi, M. (2018). “News comes across when I’m in a moment of leisure”: Understanding the practices of incidental news consumption on social media. *New media & Society*, 20(10), 3523–3539
4. Mitova, E., Blassnig, S., Strikovic, E., Urman, A., Hannak, A., de Vreese, C. H., & Esser, F. (2023). News recommender systems: A programmatic research review. *Annals of the International Communication Association*, 47(1), 84-113.

Week 11, 11/02 - 11/06: Content moderation

1. Myers West, S. (2018). Censored, suspended, shadowbanned: User interpretations of content moderation on social media platforms. *New Media & Society*, 20(11), 4366-4383.
2. Gillespie, T. (2020). Content moderation, AI, and the question of scale. *Big Data & Society*, 7(2), 2053951720943234.
3. Elkin-Koren, N. (2025). Regulating Content Moderation for Democracy: A Transatlantic Divide. *Annual Review of Law and Social Science*, 21(1), 107-123.
4. Appel, R. E., Pan, J., & Roberts, M. E. (2023). Partisan conflict over content moderation is more than disagreement about facts. *Science Advances*, 9(44), eadg6799.

Week 12, 11/09 - 11/13: Generative AI and the News System

1. Lewis, S. C., Guzman, A. L., Schmidt, T. R., & Lin, B. (2025). Generative AI and its disruptive challenge to journalism: An institutional analysis. *Communication and Change*, 1(1), 9.
2. Altay, S., & Gilardi, F. (2024). People are skeptical of headlines labeled as AI-generated, even if true or human-made, because they assume full AI automation. *PNAS nexus*, 3(10), pgae403.
3. Waddell, T. F. (2026). The How and Why of Generative AI: The Effect of AI Disclosure Policies on the Perceived Trustworthiness and Financial Value of Automated News. *Mass Communication and Society*, 1-17.
4. Wang, S., & Huang, G. (2024). The impact of machine authorship on news audience perceptions: A meta-analysis of experimental studies. *Communication Research*, 51(7), 815-842.

Week 13, 11/16 - 11/20: Generative AI and Governance

1. Farrell, H. (2025). AI as Governance. *Annual Review of Political Science*, 28(1), 375-392.
2. Taeihagh, A. (2025). Governance of generative AI. *Policy and society*, 44(1), 1-22.
3. Ulnicane, I. (2025). Governance fix? Power and politics in controversies about governing generative AI. *Policy and Society*, 44(1), 70-84.
4. Schiff, K. J., Schiff, D. S., Adams, I. T., McCrain, J., & Mourtgos, S. M. (2025). Institutional factors driving citizen perceptions of AI in government: Evidence from a survey experiment on policing. *Public Administration Review*, 85(2), 451-467.

Week 14, 11/23 - 11/27: No class - Thanksgiving break**Week 15, 11/30 - 12/04: Research Presentation****Class Policies****Filming & Recording**

You may not film or record this class without permission.

Office Hours & Availability

If you do not understand any material covered in class please do not hesitate to come to my office hours. Also feel free to ask questions during the lecture. Class participation is encouraged. The best way to get a hold of me is either during office hours or via email. When you email me treat it like formal correspondence. I will do my best to respond to emails within 24 hours if received during standard business hours during the week. Expect responses in 48-72 hours for emails received on holidays or over the weekend. I will not discuss grades via email. Come see me during my office hours or before/after class if you need to discuss grades.

Moodle

I will use Moodle to post readings, supplementary material, and to sometimes make announcements. Please visit the course website on a regular basis.

Class Attendance and Hours Outside of Class

Attendance and participation are integral to your class success. Each class will build on preceding class lectures, so it is very important you attend each class. If you miss a class it is your responsibility to get notes from a peer. As a general policy, for each hour you are in class, you (the student) should plan to spend at least two hours preparing for the next class. Since this course is for three credit hours, you should expect to spend around six hours outside of class each week reading or writing assignments for the class.

Late Assignments

No late assignments will be accepted without prior communication.

Make-up Policy

Missing an exam or an assignment will result in a zero grade except under extraordinary circumstances. Such exceptional circumstances, for example, illness or medical emergencies, must be either university-approved or verified in other ways (e.g. a doctor's note indicating grave illness, not a routine check-up). In such cases, I have two expectations. First, the student will contact me as soon as physically able via email to alert me regarding the emergency. This will ideally be before the student misses the deadline. Second, students must make arrangements as soon as possible to both provide documentation of the excusable absence and reschedule the assignment or exam. I reserve the right to make make-up exams or assignments different from the original.

Laptops

There are some students that use their laptops in class effectively. There are many more that use their laptops as a means to pay partial attention. Inappropriate use of laptops in class is not just ill-advised, but it is also disruptive, distracting, and disrespectful. Use of a laptop in class is a privilege, not a right. If you abuse this privilege I will assign you a 0 for participation that day, and in some cases, you may be asked to leave. If a preponderance of students abuse this privilege I will ban laptops.

Generative AI

AI tools are now part of academic and professional work. Learning to use them appropriately is therefore valuable. At the same time, several assignments in this course are designed specifically to assess your own ability to read, reason, analyze evidence, and develop arguments. AI may support those activities, but it may not replace them.

AI may assist, but may not substitute for your intellectual work. You may brainstorm with AI, use AI to help identify or locate information **that you then verify independently**, and consult AI about theoretical or methodological questions. However, submitting AI-generated discussion responses, literature reviews, theoretical arguments, interpretations of readings, or any portions of the research paper as your own work is strictly prohibited. You are responsible for the accuracy of all claims, citations, analyses, and references in your submitted work.

Special Note on AI-Hallucinated References: You are responsible for verifying every source cited in your work. If an assignment includes a fabricated, nonexistent, or AI-hallucinated reference, the maximum grade for that assignment will be a B-, regardless of the quality of the remaining work.

LSU Student Code of Conduct

The LSU student code of conduct explains student rights and what is expected of student behavior. Students are expected to understand this code as described on the [Code of Conduct page](#). Any violations of the LSU student code will be duly reported to the Dean of Students.

Disabilities

The University is committed to making reasonable efforts to assist individuals with disabilities in their efforts to avail themselves of services and programs offered by the University. To this end, Louisiana State University will provide reasonable accommodations for persons with documented qualifying disabilities. If you have a disability and feel you need accommodations in this course, you must present a letter to me from Disability Services in 124 Johnston Hall, indicating the existence of a disability and the suggested accommodations.

Academic Success

The primary ingredients of your academic success are attending class, managing your time efficiently, taking good notes, and developing good critical thinking and communication abilities. LSU has a number of excellent resources that will assist you in developing these skills. The place to begin is the **Center for Academic Success** (CAS). The CAS offers guidance on what learning strategies are best suited to your talents, tutoring in the basic subjects, and workshops on a variety of topics, from note-taking to time management. **Communication Across the Curriculum** assists students in developing the communication skills necessary for academic and professional success. Finally, with respect to professional success, the **LSU Olinde Career Center** can assist you in choosing a major and a profession that best suits your talents and passions and help you develop a four-year career plan to ensure success when you graduate from LSU.

Diversity, Equity & Inclusion Statement

We believe diversity, equity, and inclusion enrich the educational experience of our students, faculty, and staff, and are necessary to prepare all people to thrive personally and professionally in a global society. Therefore, LSU is firmly committed to an environment that affords respect to all members of our community. We will work to eliminate barriers that any members of our community experience.

To make LSU a place where that can happen, we must recognize and reflect on the inglorious aspects of our history. We now acknowledge the need to confront the ways racism, sexism, ableism, ageism, classism, LGBTQ+ phobia, intolerance based on religion or on national origin, and all forms of bias and exploitation have shaped our everyday lives.

We accept personal and professional responsibility to eliminate bias and oppression wherever they are found. We understand our obligation to speak up when we see bias whether it be in our teaching, study, or daily work. Our community will educate themselves proactively and continuously about how to intervene and bring bias to the attention of others with commitment and compassion.

We will hold ourselves accountable for our actions and inactions, and for maintaining intentional, measurable, and meaningful efforts to enhance diversity, equity, and inclusion, including through ongoing evaluation of our policies, practices, and procedures.

Nondiscrimination, Sexual Harassment, & Title IX

LSU provides equal opportunity for all qualified persons in admission to, participation in, or employment in the programs and activities which the university operates without regard to race, creed, color, marital status, sexual orientation, gender identity, gender expression, religion, sex,

national origin, age, mental or physical disability, or veteran's status. LSU has implemented a procedure to address complaints for those who believe they have been subjected to discrimination and/or harassment in violation of this policy. Please know that your instructors are here to support you and listen to your experience. We also want you to know that we are mandatory reporters and must report what we know to the Office of Civil Rights and Title IX. All LSU employees, with few exceptions, are required to report instances of sex- or gender-based harassment and discrimination, including sexual misconduct and power-based violence (e.g., sexual assault, stalking, dating violence, domestic violence, sexual exploitation, retaliation, etc.) for which they may not be the victim, but of which they are aware. The Office of Civil Rights & Title IX is the LSU office responsible for investigating complaints regarding any type of discrimination, sexual harassment, or power-based violence. The Office of Civil Rights & Title IX is located in 118 Himes Hall and the phone number is 225-578-9000. If you are aware of an individual who has been victimized, you are encouraged to contact the Office of Civil Rights & Title IX or file an online report by visiting [LSU's Title IX](#) website and clicking the [Report an Incident](#) box. If you have been assaulted, harassed, or a victim of violence, we encourage you to contact the Office of Civil Rights & Title IX. Please reach out for help immediately. Some excellent resources available to Baton Rouge residents include:

- STAR (Sexual Trauma Awareness and Response; 24/7 hotline: 855-435-STAR (7827)
- IRIS Domestic Violence Center; 24/7 hotline: 800-541-9706
- The Lighthouse Program; 225-578-5718
- VIA LINK; 800-273-TALK (8255) [national line but answered from New Orleans]

National resources include:

- RAINN (Rape, Abuse & Incest National Network); 24/7 hotline: 800-656-4673
- National Sexual Violence Resource Center

For additional information, visit www.lsu.edu/civil-rights the [Office of Civil Rights & Title IX](#) and review [PM-73](#) (Prohibiting Power-based Violence, including Sex- and Gender-based Harassment and Discrimination, and Sexual Misconduct).

LSU Collegiate Recovery Program

Louisiana State University is committed to being inclusive to students in recovery, and to assisting students who are exploring recovery resources. LSU's Collegiate Recovery Program is geared toward helping students remain in recovery while at LSU and seeks to advocate for students' recovery when applicable. If you have questions about LSU's Collegiate Recovery Program or available resources, please call 225-578-4826 or email asinge6@lsu.edu.

Wellbeing

Your sense of wellbeing is influenced by many parts of your life. The extent to which you feel happy, healthy and otherwise fulfilled matters to us at LSU. Should you need direction to address

any number of problems you may have that is directly influencing your sense of wellbeing, please visit lsu.edu/lsucares or complete the [LSU wellbeing resources and support form](#) to inquire as to specific offices to address your concerns. Please note the form is for non-emergency matters. For those matters requiring immediate attention, call the LSU police at 225-578-3231 or LSU Cares at 225-578-4307. For free, confidential, 24/7 emotional support and crisis management, call or text The Phone at 225-924-5781 (LSU1) or the Lifeline at 988.

Remote Learning

In the event of a campus-wide closure, this course may transition to an alternative form of instruction. I will notify you by Moodle announcement as soon as possible of the format our course will take. For example, the class may be held via Zoom and recorded for those unable to attend, or I will provide a lesson online that you can do asynchronously, or we may cover content at a different pace or schedule. If the emergency closure impacts scheduled tests, I will make alternative arrangements as soon as possible. If alternative formats are not available due to widespread loss of power and/or internet or other extenuating circumstances, the University may schedule makeup days per [Policy Statement 117](#).

Grade Review

I am willing to review a written request to review a grade submitted no earlier than one-week following receipt of the grade, and no later than 4 weeks after receipt of the grade. If such a request is made, students must be prepared that a review may result in either a lower or higher grade.